



△ STILL WATERS

An Australian pelican glides along the Murray River in the Riverland region of South Australia. The Murray-Darling basin is home to almost 100 species of waterbirds.

▽ RIVER'S END

Just before emptying into the ocean, the Murray-Darling connects with the Coorong, a narrow channel of lagoons lying behind the Younghusband Peninsula.



Jenolan Caves

A complex Australian cave system containing elaborate formations, the oldest caves ever discovered

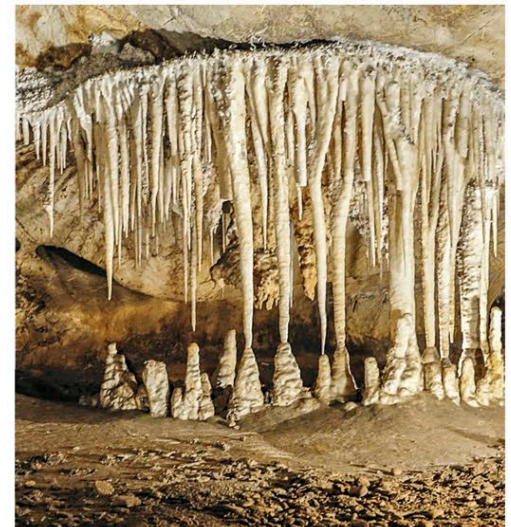


Situated on the western flank of the Blue Mountains in New South Wales, the Jenolan Caves are the best-known limestone cave system in Australasia. They sit within a narrow, uplifted ridge of limestone formed 500 million years ago, when the area was submerged beneath the ocean. The Jenolan Caves comprise a series of water-carved passages and caverns that stretch for more than 25 miles (40 km), over different levels, with more than 300 entrances. One of the largest caves, the Lucas Cave, has several vast sections including the 177-ft- (54-m-) high Cathedral Chamber, which is famous for its excellent acoustics. Scientists have estimated that the Jenolan Caves date back more than 340 million years, making them by far the oldest caves ever discovered.



▷ LARGE CRYSTALS

Deposits of a form of calcite called dogtooth spar, consisting of large crystals formed over long periods, are found in the pools of the Jenolan Caves.



△ RICH DECORATIONS

The caves are renowned for their rich and varied deposits, including stalactites, stalagmites, columns, arches, and other intricate calcite formations.

Waitomo Caves

An underground network of New Zealand caves, many decorated by the luminescence of glowworms



In the area of Waitomo, in the west of New Zealand's North Island, runs a 28-mile- (45-km-) long network of caves, passages, and grottoes beneath fields of open farmland. The Waitomo Caves formed within a section of 30-million-year-old limestone rock up to (330 ft 100 m) thick. Fractures and fault lines in the rock allowed water to percolate through, creating an underground drainage system that gradually increased in size and complexity. Many of the caves and passages have streams with waterfalls running through them, and most feature a combination of calcite formations including stalactites, stalagmites, and columns in shades of brown, pink, and white. The best known of the 300 caves in the region are the Glowworm Caves, Ruakuri Cave, Aranui Cave, and Gardner's Gut.

▷ GLOWWORM GROTTO

The ceilings of many of the Waitomo Caves are lit up by thousands of tiny glowworms, the larvae of a species of gnat endemic to New Zealand.

